Deviance, Crime, and Social Control

Dr. Fatima Alqabandi · Kuwait University

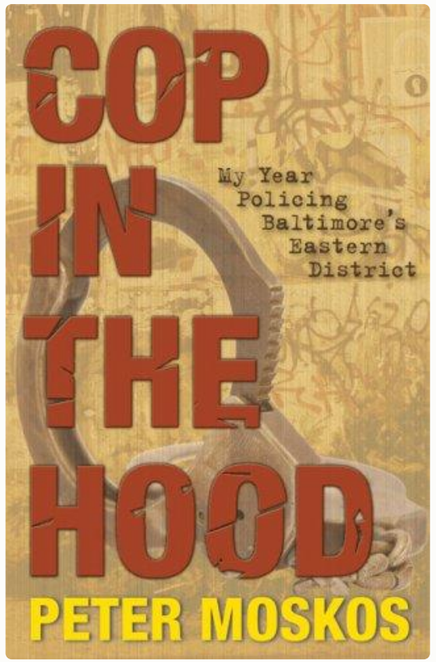
Chapter 7 · Based on Richard T. Schaefer, *Sociology: A Brief Introduction*, 14th ed.

Peter Moskos: A Sociologist in the Baltimore Police

To study crime firsthand, a sociologist joined the police. His patrol raises the questions in this chapter: who breaks rules, who enforces them, and who gets counted.

What Peter Moskos Learned in 20 Months as a Baltimore Police Officer

- Sociologist **Peter Moskos** entered Baltimore's police academy to study policing. A new commissioner challenged him: "Why don't you want to be a cop for real?" So he became one
- For **20 months** he patrolled the Eastern District, answering everything from disorderly conduct to a 12-person shooting. His book *Cop in the Hood* (2008) is an **ethnographic study** (Chapter 2)
- His central point: "Police don't deal with a random cross-section of society." The people officers meet are not typical of the neighborhood, and "the noncriminal public, the routine, and the working folks all get short shrift"



Princeton University Press, 2008.

> An officer's picture of a neighborhood comes from the calls the officer answers. What would that picture leave out of your own neighborhood?

Conformity or Deviance Depends on the Reference Group

- **Binge drinking** violates a school's standards and endangers health, so it is **deviant**. To a peer group that expects it, it is **conforming**
- "Conformity" can mean mindless imitation, like executives all in gray suits, or being a cooperative "team player"
- A police officer who uses excessive force may be seen by some colleagues as someone "who has their back," and by others as making public safety harder



A car drifting in tyre smoke. Wikimedia Commons, CC0.

> A young man drifts a car in an empty lot while his friends film it. To the friends, is he deviant or conforming? To the traffic police? To his mother?

What Is Deviance?

Sociologists use *deviance* for any violation of a group's standards. What counts as deviant depends on the group, the era, and who has the power to define it.

Deviance Is Behavior That Violates a Group's Standards

- **Deviance** — behavior that violates the standards of conduct or expectations of a group or society. To sociologists it does not mean perversion or depravity
- Being late for class is deviant; so is wearing jeans to a formal wedding. By this definition, **we are all deviant from time to time** (Best 2004)
- Deviance goes far beyond crime. An official who takes a bribe and a student who cuts class have both broken norms
- Deviance is **not always negative**:
  - A manager who turns down a relative's *wasta* request and hires the best-qualified applicant is deviating from what the family expects
  - A couple who choose a small, simple wedding when relatives expect a lavish one are deviating from family norms
  - A student who refuses to share answers in the class group chat during an online quiz is deviating from the group's norm
  - A police officer who blows the whistle on corruption or brutality in the department is deviating from its norms too

Deviance Is Socially Defined and Changes over Time

- What counts as deviant is set by **social definition**, in a particular society at a particular time
- Usually the people with the most **status and power** decide what is acceptable
- **Smoking:** doctors warned about tobacco from 1964, yet smoking stayed acceptable for decades, partly because of the power of tobacco farmers and manufacturers. A long public health campaign made it more deviant
- **Tattoos:** long banned for U.S. military recruits. The Navy lifted its ban in 2012 and the Army in 2015, with limits on visibility and content



Camel advertisement, 1948: "More doctors smoke Camels." Internet Archive Book Images.

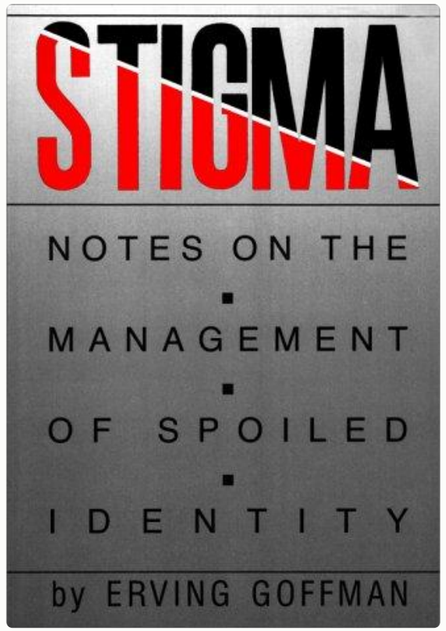
Deviant Where, When, and to Whom? Sort the Cases

For each act, name a setting where it is ordinary and a setting where it is deviant. Then name who decides.

- Eating a sandwich on a public street at noon, during the daylight hours of Ramadan
- Answering a phone call in a lecture
- Wearing gym clothes to a wedding
- Smoking inside a café in 1995, and today
- Using AI to brainstorm an essay with disclosure, and using AI during an exam
- Disagreeing openly with a senior colleague in a meeting

Goffman’s Concept of Stigma

- Some people are cast in **negative social roles** because of physical or behavioral traits. Once labeled, they struggle to present a positive image and may lose self-esteem
- **Stigma** — Erving Goffman’s term for the labels society uses to devalue members of certain social groups, such as “short people” or “redheads” (Goffman 1963)
- In many families, a visit to a psychiatrist is kept quiet for fear the label will follow the patient, and even the patient’s siblings, into marriage proposals. The stigma covers a whole category of people, whatever their condition
- In 2020, people who tested positive for COVID-19, and sometimes their whole families, were avoided even after they recovered. Schaefer lists “COVID-19 survivor” among the labels that can stick to a person
- Which jobs carried a stigma for young Kuwaitis a generation ago, such as barista or shop cashier? Which still do? The work stayed the same; did the label?



Goffman, *Stigma* (1963).

Prestige Symbols, Stigma Symbols, and Labels That Stick

- Labels such as “ex-convict,” “recovering alcoholic,” or “ex-mental patient” can stick for life, long after the behavior has stopped
- Goffman: a **prestige symbol** draws attention to a positive part of one’s identity, such as a wedding band. A **stigma symbol** discredits it, such as a criminal conviction
- Stigma symbols are not always visible, but they can become public through records or social media
- Some deviance stigmatizes a person; some carries no real penalty



A wedding band, Goffman’s example of a prestige symbol. Petar Milošević, CC BY-SA 4.0.

Technology Redefines the Norms of Online Behavior

- New technology creates situations with no norms yet. Early internet anonymity made harsh comments and chat-room hogging common, and people now call for formal rules (Chapter 6)
- Some deviant uses of technology are crimes, though not everyone sees them that way. Downloading copyrighted music is **widely accepted**, and despite industry campaigns, **no social stigma** attaches to it

Deviance is a complex concept. Sometimes it is trivial, sometimes profoundly harmful. Sometimes society accepts it, and sometimes society soundly rejects it.

Which Online Behaviors Carry a Stigma? Rank the Cases

Rank these from “nobody cares” to “people would cut you off.” Then mark the ones that are illegal.

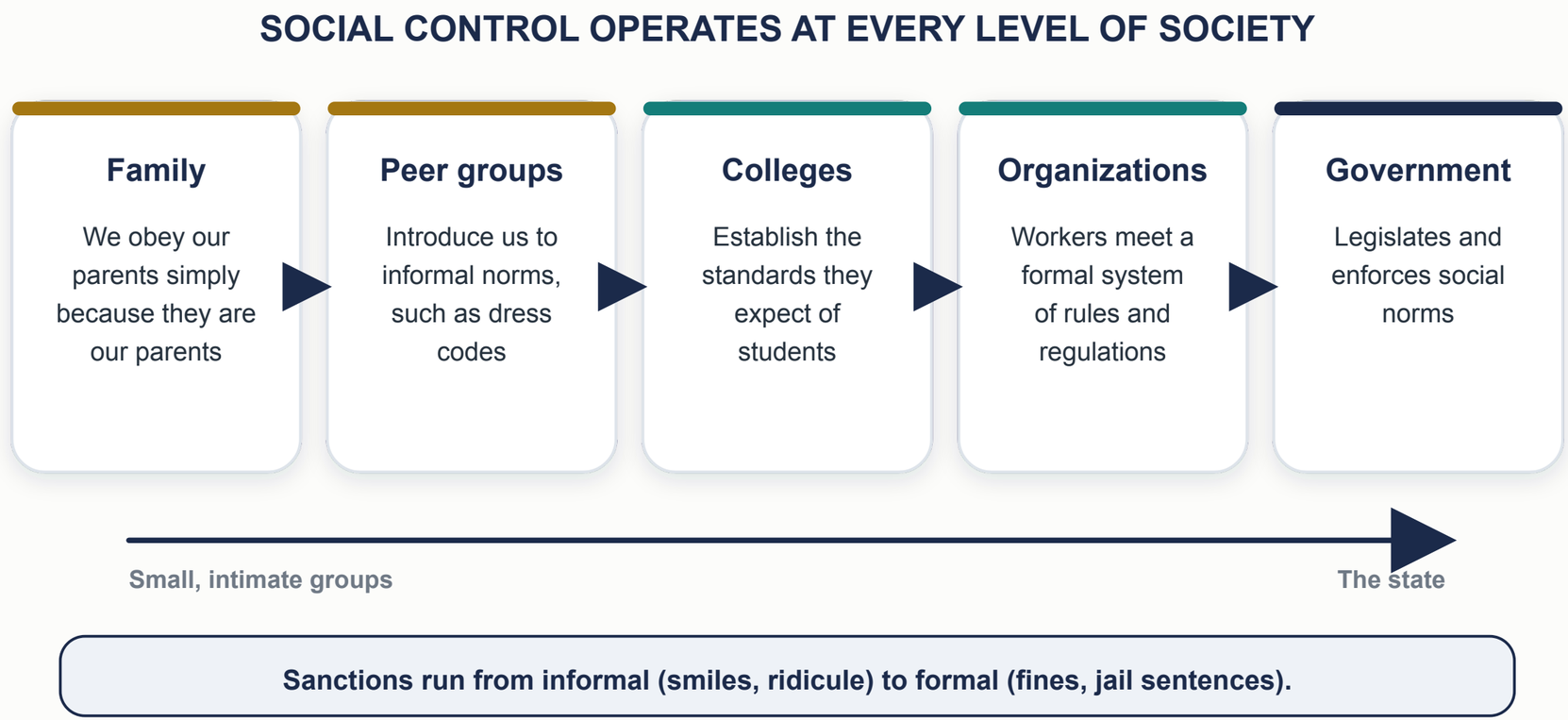
1. Streaming a football match through an unofficial link
2. Sharing a friend’s password for a streaming service
3. Screenshotting a private chat and posting it to a group
4. Leaving a family WhatsApp group without a word
5. Posting a fake five-star review for a cousin’s restaurant
6. Reading a message and not replying for three days

Social Control

Every group has ways to keep its members in line, from a raised eyebrow to a prison sentence. Most of the time we comply without noticing.

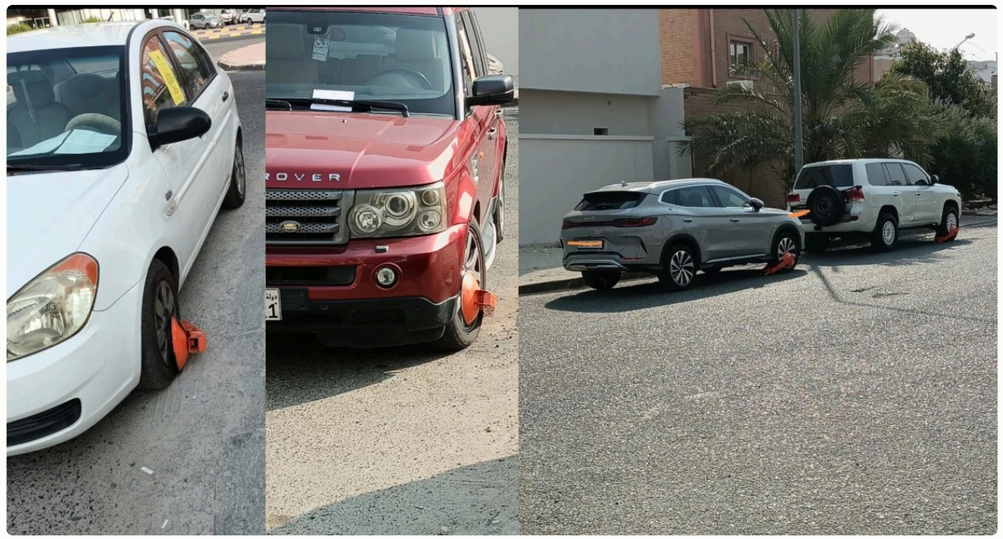
Social Control Operates at Every Level of Society

- **Social control** — the techniques and strategies for preventing deviant human behavior in any society
- Laws, dress codes, organizational bylaws, course requirements, and the rules of sports and games all express social norms (Chapter 3)



Sanctions and Competing Messages About How to Behave

- Most of us follow basic norms without thinking: we obey police officers and move to the back of the elevator. That is effective **socialization**
- **Sanctions** — penalties and rewards for conduct concerning a social norm. They can be **informal**, such as ridicule, or **formal**, such as fines and jail
- People often get **competing messages**: the law says one thing, friends or co-workers encourage another
- The recent changes and increased enforcement of traffic laws in Kuwait.



Clamped cars on residential streets in Kuwait, October 2026.

Functionalist and Conflict Views of Social Control

- **Functionalists:** a society could not function if large numbers of people defied its norms
- **Conflict theorists:** the successful functioning of a society consistently benefits the powerful at others' expense
- Their evidence: in the United States, resisting norms was necessary to win independence, end slavery, win women the vote, and secure civil rights



Woman Suffrage Procession, Washington, D.C., 1913. U.S. National Archives, public domain.

Milgram Distinguished Conformity from Obedience

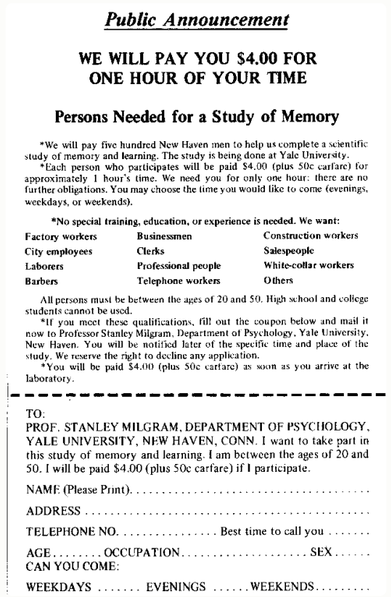
- **Conformity** — going along with peers, people of our own status who have no special right to direct our behavior (Milgram 1975)
- **Obedience** — compliance with higher authorities in a hierarchical structure
- A military recruit **conforms** to other recruits' habits and language, and **obeys** superior officers



Recruits in formation facing their instructors. Michael Tolzmann, U.S. Air Force, public domain.

The Milgram Experiment: Teachers, Learners, and a Shock Generator

- Milgram recruited ordinary people in New Haven, from postal clerks to engineers, for a Yale study of the effects of **punishment on learning**
- An experimenter in a gray technician's coat ran a rigged draw: the real subject was always the "**teacher**," and Milgram's associate played the "**learner**"
- The teacher sat at a "shock generator" with **30** switches from **15** to **450** volts and was told to raise the voltage after every wrong answer
- **The learner received no shocks.** The teacher did not know that



Public Announcement

WE WILL PAY YOU $4.00 FOR ONE HOUR OF YOUR TIME

Persons Needed for a Study of Memory

*We will pay five hundred New Haven men to help us complete a scientific study of memory and learning. The study is being done at Yale University.

*Each person who participates will be paid $4.00 (plus 50c carfare) for approximately 1 hour's time. We need you for only one hour: there are no further obligations. You may choose the time you would like to come (evenings, weekdays, or weekends).

***No special training, education, or experience is needed. We want:**

Factory workers	Businessmen	Construction workers
City employees	Clerks	Salespeople
Laborers	Professional people	White-collar workers
Barbers	Telephone workers	Others

All persons must be between the ages of 20 and 50. High school and college students cannot be used.

*If you meet these qualifications, fill out the coupon below and mail it now to Professor Stanley Milgram, Department of Psychology, Yale University, New Haven. You will be notified later of the specific time and place of the study. We reserve the right to decline any application.

*You will be paid $4.00 (plus 50c carfare) as soon as you arrive at the laboratory.

TO:
PROF. STANLEY MILGRAM, DEPARTMENT OF PSYCHOLOGY, YALE UNIVERSITY, NEW HAVEN, CONN. I want to take part in this study of memory and learning. I am between the ages of 20 and 50. I will be paid $4.00 (plus 50c carfare) if I participate.

NAME (Please Print). . . . . .

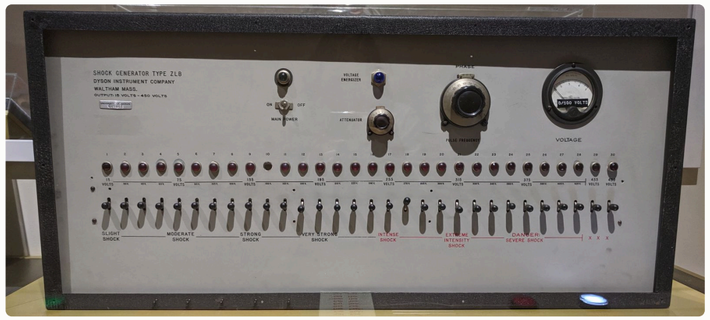
ADDRESS . . . . . .

TELEPHONE NO. . . . . Best time to call you . . . . . .

AGE . . . . . OCCUPATION . . . . . SEX . . . . . .

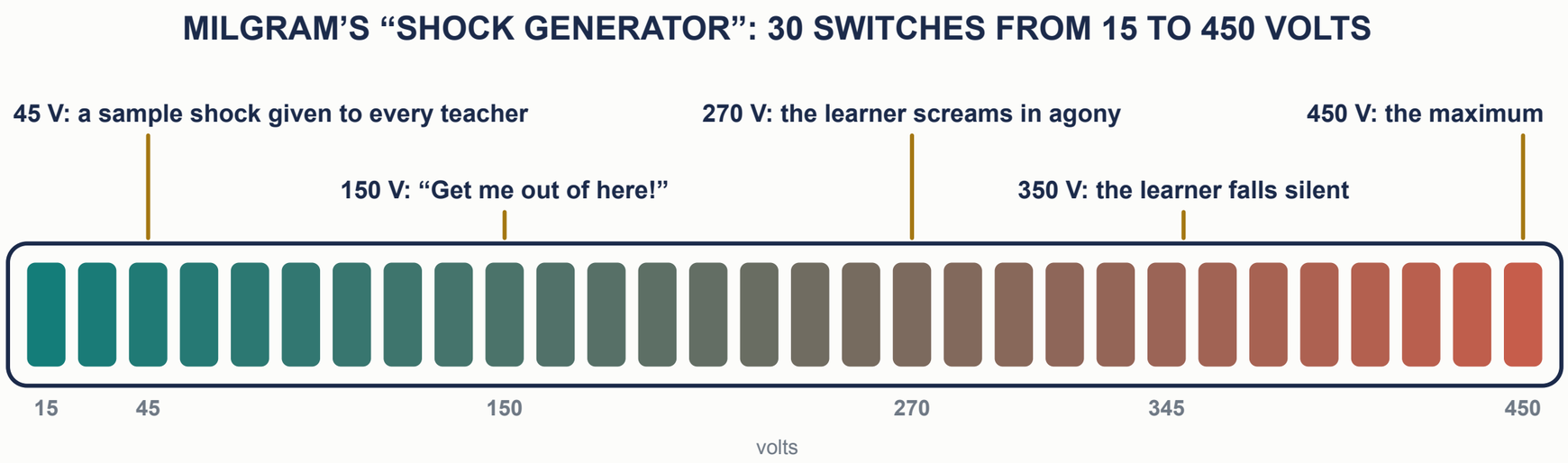
CAN YOU COME:

WEEKDAYS . . . . . EVENINGS . . . . . WEEKENDS . . . . . .



Milgram's recruitment ad and the original shock generator.

Predict: How Many Teachers Obeyed to the End?



The learner, Milgram's associate, received no shocks. When a teacher hesitated, the experimenter insisted: "The experiment requires that you continue." "You have no other choice; you must go on."

Milgram 1963, 1975. Instructor illustration; the 350-volt point falls between the 345- and 360-volt switches.

> Out of 100 ordinary people in the teacher's chair, how many would you predict become "obedient subjects"?

- A sample of **psychiatrists** predicted that virtually all subjects would refuse. Only a "pathological fringe" of **less than 2 percent** would continue to the maximum level
- In fact, **almost two-thirds** of participants fell into the category of "obedient subjects" (Milgram 1975:19–23)

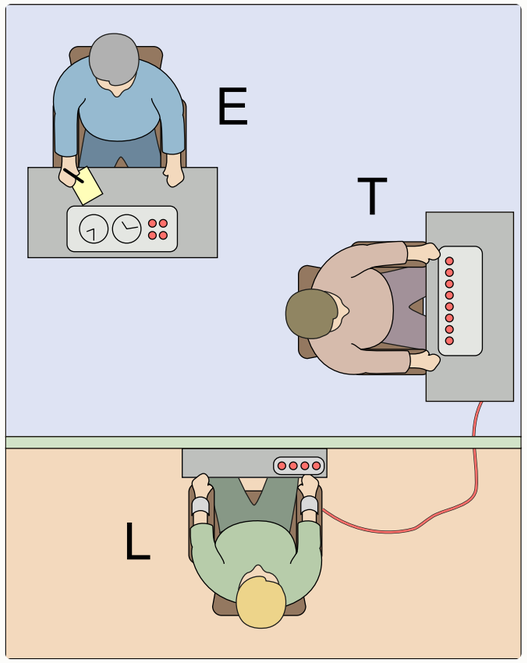
Why Did Milgram's Subjects Obey?

- The subjects were not unusually sadistic. Few seemed to enjoy giving the shocks
- Milgram pointed to the experimenter's **social role**. We are used to obeying **impersonal authority figures** marked by a title (professor, doctor) or a uniform (the technician's coat)
- Subjects **shifted responsibility** to the authority: "If it were up to me, I would not have administered shocks"

- **Would people still obey today?** In 2006 **Jerry Burger** repeated part of the study with undergraduates and found **70 percent** full obedience, not significantly different from Milgram's **82.5 percent** at the same point (Burger 2009, 2014)
- **Virtual reality** versions agree: teachers feel similar stress and still largely obey (Cornet and Van Gelder 2020; Slater et al. 2006)

The Interactionist Reading: Physical Distance and 15-Volt Steps

- When teachers were moved physically **closer** to the learner, fewer gave shocks
- In one version, the learner refused at 150 volts to touch the shock plate. **40 percent** of teachers stopped; **30 percent** forced his hand onto it
- The voltage rose **15 volts at a time**, so the experimenter was negotiating with the teacher step by step
- Obedience would probably have been far lower had the first order been 450 volts (Allen 1978; Katovich 1987)



Standard setup: experimenter (E) and teacher (T) in one room, learner (L) behind a wall. Fred the Oyster, CC BY-SA 4.0.

Use Your Sociological Imagination: Would You Have Obeyed?

If you were a participant in Milgram's research, how far do you think you would go in carrying out orders?

- Schaefer asks: do you see an ethical problem with the experimenter's manipulation of the subjects? Check it against Chapter 2's ethical duties, including informed consent
- Which condition would make you most likely to stop: a victim in the same room, bigger jumps in voltage, or an experimenter without a coat?
- Where in your future field will someone with a title or a uniform tell you to continue?

Informal and Formal Social Control

- **Informal social control** — used casually to enforce norms: a smile, laughter, a raised eyebrow, ridicule
- Many adults treat spanking or slapping children as proper informal control. Child development specialists say it teaches children to solve problems through violence, and research links it, even alongside warm parenting, to adolescent social conduct disorder
- **Formal social control** — carried out by authorized agents such as police, judges, school administrators, and employers. Often a **last resort** when socialization and informal sanctions fail
- Informal control can **undermine** formal control, encouraging people to break norms

Informal or Formal? Sort the Sanction

Classify each sanction as informal or formal.

1. An aunt’s comment about your weight at a family lunch
2. A speed-camera fine that appears on your phone
3. The class group chat goes quiet after your message
4. A professor deducts marks for a late assignment
5. “What will people say?” (*kalam al-nas*)
6. A mall security guard asks you to stop filming
7. Friends cheer when you finally quit vaping
8. A diwaniya laughs about someone’s new car

Formal Social Control: The Death Penalty and Surveillance

- The **death penalty** is meant to deter others as much as to punish. Researchers have not been able to establish what deterrent effect, if any, it has
- After **September 11, 2001**, the United States expanded surveillance at airports and high-rise buildings and asked citizens to report suspicious behavior (Monahan 2011)
- Civil rights advocates warned this would encourage stereotyping of **Muslims and Arab Americans**. There is a clear trade-off between surveillance and **privacy**



A portable “Rased” speed camera on a Kuwaiti highway, 2025. *Kuwait Times*.

> Speed cameras, mall CCTV, and the location data on your phone: which did you agree to, and which were simply installed?

Law and Society

Some norms matter so much that a society writes them into law. Sociologists study lawmaking as a social process that shows whose values prevail.

Law Is Governmental Social Control

- **Law** — governmental social control (Black 1995). Some laws apply to everyone, such as the ban on murder; others apply to particular groups or institutions
- Sociologists treat lawmaking as a **social process** that reflects changing standards of right and wrong (Schur 1968)
- The legal order reflects the values of **those in authority**, so making a law means choosing among competing values
- Laws without public support behind them are **hard to enforce**



Kuwait's National Assembly in session, 1963. Hassan Hamdy Wahidy, public domain.

Which Laws Are Likely to Change Next?

Schaefer: law reflects changing standards of right and wrong. Which laws do you think are likely to change soon because social standards are changing?

- Start with technology that arrived faster than its rules: e-scooters, drones, delivery-bike riders, deepfake images, AI in coursework
- Which rule in daily life here is widely ignored because few people support it? What would it take to enforce it: more cameras, higher fines, or a change in opinion?
- Schaefer also asks: should some illegal drugs be decriminalized? Why or why not?



A rental e-scooter recovered from the river Main, Frankfurt, 2021. Matti Blume, CC BY-SA 4.0.

Socialization and Hirschi's Control Theory

- **Socialization** is the main source of conformity. We have **internalized** norms, and we want to be seen as loyal, cooperative, and responsible
- **Control theory** — our connection to members of society leads us to systematically conform. For **Travis Hirschi**, bonds to family, friends, and peers keep us following norms (Hirschi 1969)
- The media focus on crime, but **most members of most societies conform** to basic norms (Schmalleger 2020)

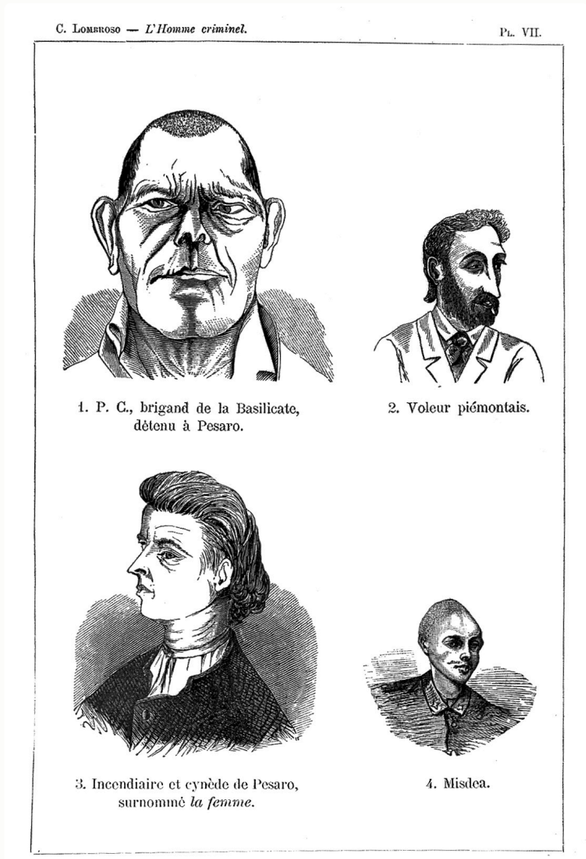
> Think, privately, of a rule you were tempted to break this week: skipping a lecture, or running an empty red light at 3 a.m. What stopped you: the fine, or the thought of who would find out?

Sociological Perspectives on Deviance

If sanctions are everywhere, why does deviance happen at all? Each perspective answers a different part of the question: why rules are broken, how people learn to break them, and who gets labeled for it.

Early Explanations Blamed the Supernatural and Biology

- Early explanations blamed supernatural forces or “bad blood.” Nineteenth-century research on biological causes of crime was **discredited** in the 20th century
- Some biochemists now look for genes linked to traits such as **aggression**. But aggression also brings success in business and sports, and criminality is hardly a personality trait
- Sociologists are generally critical of genetic explanations and look to social ones (Cohen 2011)



“Criminal types” from Cesare Lombroso’s *L’Homme criminel*. Wellcome Collection, CC BY 4.0.

Functionalist View: Deviance Defines the Limits of Proper Behavior

- Functionalists see deviance as a normal part of social life, with **positive as well as negative** consequences for stability
- **Émile Durkheim** ([1895] 1964): punishments show everyone where the line is. Without them, people might stretch their standards of conduct
- A child who sees one parent scold the other for belching at dinner learns the rule. So does a student penalized for a paper handed in weeks late



Émile Durkheim. Public domain.

> A student in a 200-seat course is penalized for plagiarism. What do the other 199 students learn?

Durkheim’s Anomie: Normlessness During Profound Change

- **Anomie** — Durkheim’s ([1897] 1951) term for the loss of direction felt in a society when social control of individual behavior has become ineffective
- It typically appears during revolution, sudden prosperity, or economic collapse. People agree less on proper behavior, and rates of **violent crime and suicide** rise (Chapter 1)


LE

SUICIDE

ÉTUDE DE SOCIOLOGIE

PAR

ÉMILE DURKHEIM

Professeur de Sociologie à la Faculté des Lettres de l'Université de Bordeaux

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FÉLIX ALCAN, ÉDITEUR

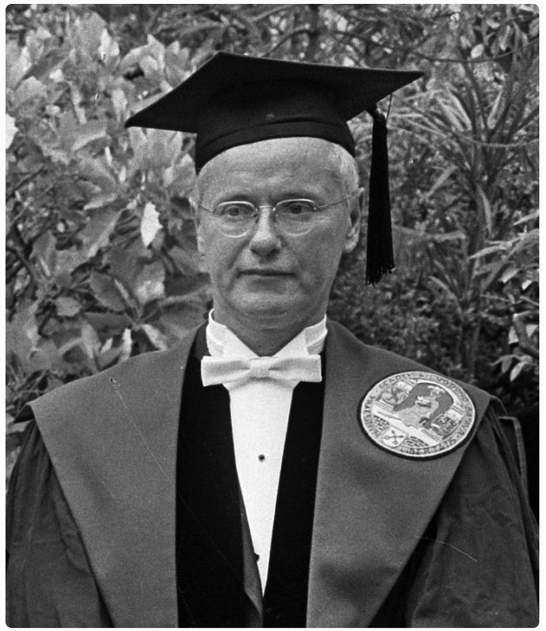
1897

Tous droits réservés.

Title page of *Le Suicide* (1897). Internet Archive, public domain.

Merton: Cultural Goals and Institutional Means

- What do a mugger and a teacher have in common? Both are “working” for money to buy the things they want
- **Robert Merton** (1968): U.S. culture sets **success**, measured largely in money, as a goal, and approves certain **means** of reaching it: school, hard work, persistence
- People can accept or reject the goals, the means, or both. Merton’s **anomie theory of deviance** names five ways of adapting



Robert K. Merton, 1965. Eric Koch / Anefo, CC0.

Merton’s Five Modes of Adaptation

- **Goal** — what society tells you to want: success, measured largely in money
- **Means** — the approved ways to get it: school, a job, hard work

Mode	Still wants success?	Still uses the approved ways?	Example
Conformity	Yes	Yes	An employee works long hours to earn a promotion and a raise. The only nondeviant mode
Innovation	Yes	No: finds a shortcut	A hacker steals money for consumer goods and vacations
Ritualism	No: has given up on it	Yes: follows the rules for their own sake	A caseworker refuses to help a homeless family because their last apartment was in another district
Retreatism	No	No: drops out of both	In the United States, drug addicts and vagrants are typically portrayed this way
Rebellion	No: wants different goals	No: wants a different system	Members of a revolutionary political organization

- Merton’s insight: innovators and ritualists **share a great deal with conformists**. Deviance is **socially created**, not a momentary pathological impulse
- The weakness: the theory has **not been applied systematically** to real-world crime

Merton’s Five Modes at University and Work

Schaefer asks for an example of each of Merton’s five modes from work or college life. Start by classifying these.

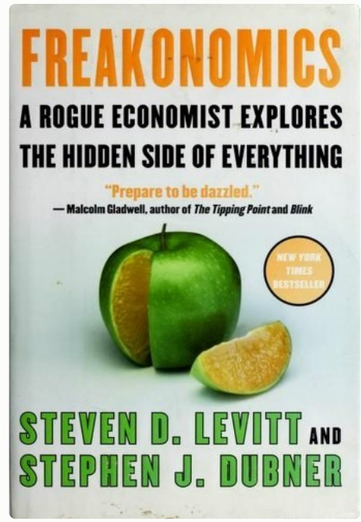
1. A student buys a finished project online to protect a high GPA
2. A student studies every night to win a place in medical school
3. A ministry clerk rejects a form because it was signed in blue ink instead of black
4. A student has stopped caring about grades or a degree, and has stopped coming
5. An engineer lists a certificate on her CV that she never earned
6. A graduate rejects the degree-to-job path and founds a cooperative where pay does not depend on credentials

> Which case did the room disagree about most? What would you need to know about the person’s goals to decide?

Box 7-3: Does Crime Pay? Predict the Gang Leaders' Earnings

- Sociologist **Sudhir Venkatesh** observed a **Chicago street gang** and collected detailed data on its drug trade. Economist **Steven Levitt**, coauthor of *Freakonomics*, helped him analyze the business

> What share of the gang's **leaders** do you think earned $100,000 a year? What did the rank and file earn?

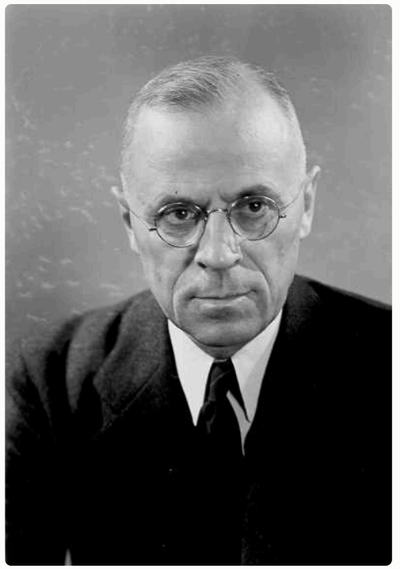


Levitt and Dubner, *Freakonomics* (2005).

- **Less than 5 percent** of even the gang leaders earned $100,000 a year. Almost all the rank and file earned **less than the minimum wage**, and most were unpaid, hoping to move up
- Levitt's chapter title: "Why Do Drug Dealers Still Live with Their Moms?" Like most corporations, the top **2 percent** take home most of the money
- So why does the trade persist? Demand for illegal drugs is high, and legitimate jobs for young people in poor areas are scarce

Interactionist View: Sutherland's Cultural Transmission and Differential Association

- Functionalists explain why rule-breaking persists. Interactionists explain how a **particular person** comes to break rules
- **Edwin Sutherland**: we learn deviant behavior through the **same socialization** that teaches conforming behavior
- **Cultural transmission** — one learns criminal behavior by interacting with others: the **techniques** of lawbreaking and the **motives and rationalizations** for it
- **Differential association** — the process through which exposure to attitudes favorable to criminal acts leads to the violation of rules. An outgoing, athletic boy in a high-delinquency area may join peers who vandalize; in another neighborhood, he joins a soccer team
- **Critics:** it fits graffiti crews and delinquent gangs, but not the first-time impulsive shoplifter or someone who steals out of need (Sutherland et al. 1992)



Edwin H. Sutherland. Wikimedia Commons, CC BY-SA 4.0.

Who Taught the Technique, and Who Taught the Excuse?

Pick a minor rule-breaking you have seen among people your age: vaping in a car, cutting a bakery line, slipping a phone into an exam, drifting in an empty lot.

- Who taught the **technique**? Where did people learn to do it without getting caught?
- Who taught the **rationalization**: “everyone does it,” “the rule is pointless,” “nobody gets hurt”?
- Sutherland’s outgoing boy joins a soccer team in one neighborhood and a vandal crew in another. What plays the soccer team’s role for young people here?

Predict: What Happened to Zimbardo's Two Abandoned Cars?

- Philip Zimbardo, author of Chapter 5's mock prison experiment, **abandoned a car** in each of two neighborhoods. He left each car's hood up, removed its hubcaps, and set up a remote video camera to record what people did



Philip Zimbardo, 2017. Elekes Andor, CC BY-SA 4.0.

> What happened to each car, and how quickly?

- In one neighborhood, people started stripping the car for parts **before Zimbardo had finished setting up** the camera
- In the other, **weeks** passed without anyone touching the car, except a pedestrian who stopped to **close the hood** during a rainstorm (Zimbardo 2007a)

> The cars were identical. What was different about the two neighborhoods?

Social Disorganization Theory: Shaw and McKay Mapped Chicago

- **Social disorganization theory** — crime and deviance rise when communal relationships and institutions, such as family, school, church, and local government, break down
- **Clifford Shaw and Henry McKay** mapped Chicago's social problems. Rates were high where buildings had deteriorated and population had declined, and the patterns **persisted** as the residents' ethnic makeup changed (Shaw and McKay 1942)
- **Critics:** the theory can "blame the victim" and ignore larger forces, such as a lack of jobs or good schools

> Which institutions hold an area in Kuwait together: the co-op, the mosque, the diwaniya, the school? What would you expect to change if one of them closed?

The Saints and the Roughnecks: Same Behavior, Different Outcomes

Two groups of high school males engaged constantly in excessive drinking, reckless driving, truancy, petty theft, and vandalism.

The Saints

None was ever arrested.

The Roughnecks

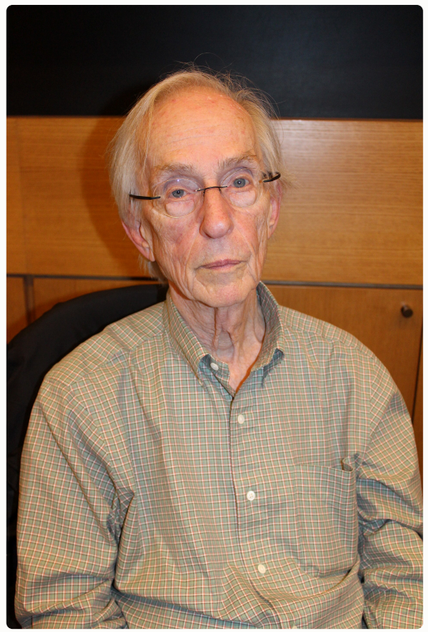
Every one was frequently in trouble with the police and townspeople.

> Why the disparity?

- Sociologist **William Chambliss** (1973; Chambliss and Haas 2012) observed their high school and concluded that **social class** mattered
- The Saints came from “good families,” got good grades, and planned to attend college. Their acts were seen as “sowing wild oats”
- The Roughnecks drove beat-up cars, did poorly in school, and aroused suspicion no matter what they did

Labeling Theory: Deviant Behavior Is Behavior That People So Label

- Labeling theory asks why some people, like the Roughnecks, are labeled deviant while others who act the same, like the Saints, are not
- **Howard Becker**: “Deviant behavior is behavior that people so label” (1963:9). This is the **societal-reaction approach**: the **response** to an act, not the act itself, determines deviance
- Labels come from **agents of social control**: police, judges, teachers, psychiatrists, employers. Their power to label ties this theory to the **conflict** perspective
- **Racial profiling** — any arbitrary action initiated by an authority based on race, ethnicity, or national origin rather than on a person’s behavior (Chapter 10)



Howard S. Becker, 2012. Thierry Caro, CC BY-SA 3.0.

Social Constructionism: How a Behavior Becomes a Social Problem

- **Social constructionism** — deviance is the product of the culture we live in. It studies the decisions that turn a behavior into a recognized problem
- “Child abductors” and “spree killers” have always existed, but **intensive media coverage** can suddenly make them a priority for policymakers
- **Smoking** went from a gentlemanly habit to a health hazard. Concern now extends to **thirdhand smoke** that clings to clothes, cars, and elevators (Winickoff et al. 2009)



An ashtray printed with a no-smoking sign. rcooper, CC BY-SA 2.0.

> Vaping was first marketed as a safer alternative to cigarettes. How is it described in the news and at home now? Who did the redefining?

You Are the Teacher: Which Labels Would You Attach?

Schaefer asks: you are a teacher. What labels, freely used in education, might you attach to your students?

- List the labels you heard at school: “gifted,” “lazy,” “the clever one,” “the troublemaker,” “the back row.” Who applied them, and when?
- A child is labeled a troublemaker in Grade 3. What does labeling theory predict by Grade 10? What would Chambliss want to know about the child’s family?
- The same direct comment in a meeting: when is it called “confident,” and when “aggressive”? Who decides?

Banksy's *Flower Thrower*: Vandalism, Artwork, or Political Protest?

- In 2003 the English street artist **Banksy** painted a work often titled *Rage, the Flower Thrower* in Jerusalem, on the West Bank barrier wall separating Israel from its occupied territories
- The image shows a protester hurling a bouquet of colorful flowers, not a Molotov cocktail
- It was one of many controversial works Banksy made to support **Palestinian rights**



The mural near Bethlehem. Photo: Jennifer Simon, CC BY 2.0; artwork © Banksy.

How do we label people's behavior? Is this vandalism? Artwork? Political protest?

Who has the authority to apply each label: the owner of the wall, the police, a museum, or the people who walk past it every day?

Conflict View: Quinney Argues That the Powerful Define Crime

- Conflict theorists: people with power **define deviance to suit their needs**
- **Richard Quinney**: crime is a definition created by legislators and law enforcement, and lawmaking is often an attempt by the powerful to **coerce others into their morality** (Quinney 1970)
- Criminal law reflects competing interests. U.S. law bans marijuana for its alleged harm, while cigarettes and alcohol, both harmful, are sold legally almost everywhere



New York agents pour liquor into a sewer during U.S. Prohibition (1920–1933). Library of Congress, public domain.

In Kuwait, alcohol is illegal and tobacco is legal. In the United States, alcohol and tobacco are legal while marijuana is federally illegal. Does Quinney's argument fit both cases equally well? How would a functionalist explain Kuwait's law?

Differential Justice: Discretion at Every Stage

- **Differential justice** — differences in the way social control is exercised over different groups
- Officials use **discretion** at every stage: to press or drop charges, set bail, grant or deny parole. Conflict theorists find these decisions disadvantage some racial, ethnic, and social-class groups (Yusef et al. 2019)
- Powerful groups are unlikely to label as “deviant” the executive whose decisions lead to large-scale environmental pollution



A courtroom of the Supreme Court of Singapore. Sgconlaw, CC BY-SA 4.0.

> List the decisions between an arrest and a sentence where someone uses discretion. At which one could money, a family name, or a phone call make the biggest difference?

Table 7-2, Part 1: Anomie, Cultural Transmission, and Social Disorganization

Each approach answers a different question about deviance. Schaefer's one-line summary of each is in bold.

Approach	The question it answers	What it says	Example from this chapter
Anomie Functionalist *Durkheim, Merton*	Why do people break rules at all?	**Adaptation to societal norms.** Society tells everyone to want success but does not give everyone an approved way to reach it, so some people adapt by breaking rules. Norms also weaken during sudden change	Merton's innovator: a hacker steals money for vacations. In an economic collapse, violent crime and suicide rise
Cultural transmission / Differential association Interactionist *Sutherland*	How does a person learn to break rules?	**Patterns learned through others.** Deviance is learned the same way conformity is, from friends and family, who teach both the techniques and the excuses	The outgoing, athletic boy who joins vandals in one neighborhood and a soccer team in another
Social disorganization Interactionist *Shaw, McKay*	Why is crime higher in some places?	**Communal relationships.** Crime rises where the institutions that hold a community together (e.g., family, school, club, local gov) have broken down	Shaw and McKay's maps of Chicago: problems stayed in the same run-down areas even as the residents changed

Table 7-2, Part 2: Labeling and Conflict Theory

Approach	The question it answers	What it says	Example from this chapter
Labeling / Social constructionist Interactionist *Becker, Chambliss*	Why are some people called deviant and others not?	**Societal response to acts.** An act becomes deviant when people with authority label it so. Who gets labeled can matter more than what they did	A child labeled "the troublemaker" in Grade 3; smoking redefined from a gentlemanly habit to a health hazard
Conflict Conflict *Quinney*	Who decides what counts as a crime?	**Dominance by authorized agents; discretionary justice.** People with power write the laws, and police, prosecutors, and judges use discretion over charges, bail, and parole in ways that favor some groups over others	U.S. law bans marijuana for its alleged harm, while alcohol and tobacco are sold legally

Schaefer asks: which sociological perspective is most useful in analyzing white-collar crime? Vandalism? Cocaine use?

Which Perspective Explains the Case Best?

Match each case to the approach in Table 7-2 that explains it best.

1. The Saints and the Roughnecks
2. A graffiti crew that trains its new members
3. A student who buys a finished project to protect a high GPA
4. One car stripped in minutes, another left untouched
5. Embezzlement punished more lightly than petty theft

Which cases needed two approaches? What does each approach leave unexplained?

Crime: A Sociological Approach

Crime is deviance that the state punishes. Sociologists sort it by how it is committed and how society views it, and the sorting shows who gets punished harshly and who rarely does.

Crime Defined: Six Types That Sociologists Distinguish

- **Crime** — a violation of criminal law for which some governmental authority applies formal penalties
- Sociologists classify crimes by **how they are committed** and **how society views them**



Sociologists classify crimes by how they are committed and how society views them.

Victimless Crime and the Debate over Decriminalization

- **Victimless crime** — the willing exchange among adults of widely desired but illegal goods and services, such as drugs
- **For decriminalization:** these acts are impossible to prevent, and police and courts should focus on crimes with obvious victims
- **Against:** compulsive gambling, drug use, and heavy drinking harm families and can lead to theft and abuse.
- Underneath the debate: who has the power to label an act a “crime,” or “victimless”?
- **In Kuwait:** a 2025 drug law allows the death penalty for trafficking. Families also file **addiction complaints** with the Public Prosecution against their own sons and daughters: **970** in 2025

> Someone bets on football through an illegal app. Who else might pay besides the bettor?

Professional and Organized Crime

- **Professional criminal** — a person who pursues crime as a day-to-day occupation, developing skilled techniques and enjoying status among other criminals. Like other workers, they form a **subculture** and trade tips (Sutherland 1937)
- **Organized crime** — the work of a group that regulates relations among criminal enterprises, such as gambling and drug smuggling. It allocates territory, sets prices, settles disputes, and "taxes" merchants for "protection"
- Organized crime has served as a route of **upward mobility**. Daniel Bell (1953) called the passing of leadership from one immigrant group to the next **ethnic succession**

White-Collar and Corporate Crime

- **White-collar crime** — illegal acts committed in the course of business activities, often by affluent, "respectable" people: tax evasion, fraud, bribery, embezzlement. **Edwin Sutherland** coined the term
- Sutherland built on **W. E. B. Du Bois**'s ([1899] 1995) observation that courts **favor the rich**: embezzlement is treated more leniently than petty theft
- **Corporate crime** — any act by a corporation that is punishable by the government, from pollution to unsafe products to accounting fraud (Simpson 2019)
- A white-collar conviction harms a career far less than a street-crime conviction. **Conflict theorists** expect this: the justice system focuses on the crimes of the poor (Simpson 2013)

White-Collar Crime in Kuwait: Recorded Bribery Cases and Perceived Corruption

- Kuwait's Public Prosecution registered between **6 and 18** cases of bribery and influence-peddling a year from 2020 to 2025. In 2025 there were **13**
- Forgery of bank documents rose from **1,078** cases in 2020 to **3,822** in 2025

The index is built from expert and business assessments of the public sector. It measures perceived corruption, not cases.

> Does "13 bribery cases" tell us how much bribery happens, or how often a bribe is reported and proven? Who would report a bribe they paid themselves?

Cybercrime and Identity Theft

- **Cybercrime** — illegal activity conducted primarily through computer hardware or software, including **cyberespionage** and **cyberterrorism**
- Its global cost was projected to reach **$6 trillion** by 2021, double the 2015 figure (Juniper Research 2015; Morgan 2017)
- **Identity theft:** about **7 percent** of adults each year find their personal information misused for crime (Harrel 2015). Cooley and Goffman wrote about the self without imagining that anyone could steal one
- **In Kuwait:** the Ministry of Interior’s cybercrime department received about **3,000** reports in 2024. The most common scams were fake messages from banks and government bodies, fake chalet-rental ads, and fake payment links

> A text says your parcel is held at customs and asks for KD 1.5 through a payment link. What is the sender really collecting?

Hate Crimes Are Defined by the Offender's Motive

- A **hate crime** (or **bias crime**) is an ordinary crime in which the offender chooses the victim because of race, religion, ethnic group, national origin, or another protected characteristic, and evidence shows **hatred** prompted it
- Hate crimes send a **message beyond the victim**. Vandalizing a mosque or a Church warns every Muslim or Christian that they are not wanted
- So many jurisdictions punish them more heavily, and the U.S. Supreme Court upheld tougher sanctions in 1993
- **In Kuwait:** We have the **2012 National Unity Law**, which bans inciting hatred or contempt of any group in society, stirring sectarian or tribal strife, or promoting the superiority of any race, color, origin, religious sect, sex, or lineage, including online. Penalties reach seven years in prison

Transnational Crime Crosses National Borders

TABLE 7-3 TYPES OF TRANSNATIONAL CRIME

Bankruptcy and insurance fraud
Computer crime (treating computers as both a tool and a target of crime)
Corruption and bribery of public officials
Counterfeiting
Environmental crime
Hijacking of airplanes (skyjacking)
Illegal drug trade
Illegal money transfers (money laundering)
Illegal sales of firearms and ammunition
Infiltration of legal businesses
Intellectual property crime
Migrant smuggling
Networking of criminal organizations
Sea piracy
Terrorism
Theft of art and cultural objects
Trafficking in body parts (includes illegal organ transplants)
Trafficking in human beings (includes sex trade)

Think about It Which of these crimes do you read or hear about the *least*? Why do you think that is?

- **Transnational crime** — crime that occurs across multiple national borders
- Historically the most dreadful example was **slavery**. Today it includes trafficking in people, drugs, endangered species, and stolen art
- The United Nations began categorizing these crimes in the 1990s (Table 7-3)

> During the 1990 invasion, collections from Kuwait's museums were taken to Iraq, and much was returned after liberation. Which row of the table describes that?

Classify the Crime: Which of the Six Types?

Name the type of crime. Some cases fit more than one.

1. A crew of pickpockets works crowded malls before Eid and shares tips on where the guards stand
2. A payment link texted to thousands of phones copies card details
3. A company hides a known defect in a car part to avoid a recall
4. A network smuggles endangered falcons across three borders
5. A group controls an underground betting market and “taxes” shopkeepers for protection
6. Insults are spray-painted on a place of worship
7. A manager pays a bribe to win a government contract

Which of these would appear in the crime statistics we discuss next, and which would almost never be counted?

Crime Statistics

Crime statistics tell us a great deal about police activity and something about crime. Reading them well means asking what they leave out.

Crime Statistics Indicate Police Activity, Not the Exact Level of Crime

- Crime statistics are often cited as if they were completely reliable. They are not
- They are an indicator of **police activity** and a rough guide to the level of certain crimes, not an exact count

> Recall Moskos: police "don't deal with a random cross-section of society." If police records are your only data, which neighborhoods and which crimes will look most common?

Kuwait’s 2020 Domestic Violence Law and the Rise in Recorded Cases

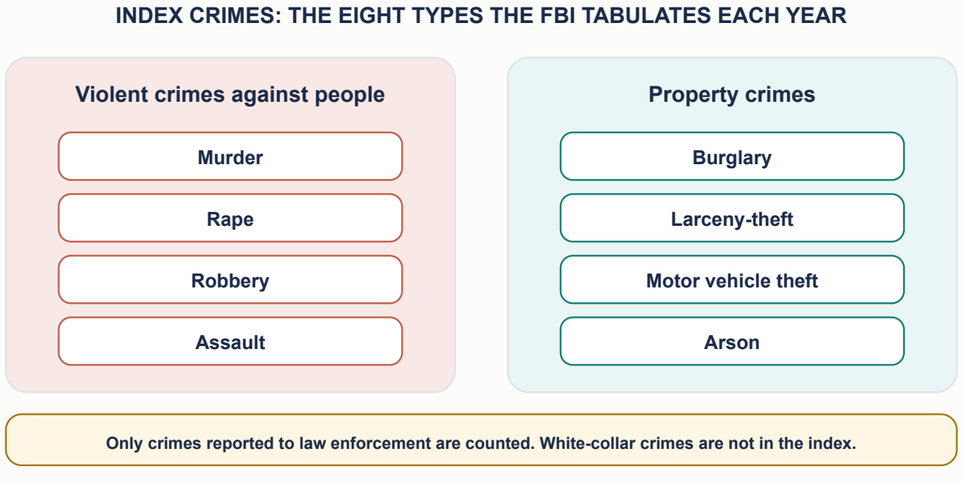
Year	Domestic violence cases
2020	263
2021	1,292
2022	2,223
2023	2,498
2024	2,405
2025	2,010

Cases registered with Kuwait’s Public Prosecution.

- **Law No. 16 of 2020** on protection from domestic violence took effect in **September 2020**
- It created protection centers, shelters, and protection orders, and it requires anyone who witnesses domestic violence to report it
- Recorded cases rose almost **tenfold** in three years

> Did violence inside families rise tenfold between 2020 and 2023? What else could change the count?

Index Crimes: The FBI's Eight Types and Their Limits



- **Index crimes** — the eight types of crime tabulated each year by the FBI
- **White-collar crimes** are left out
- The index leans toward **property** crimes, while people worry more about **violent** ones
- **The biggest limit:** it counts only crimes **reported** to police. People who distrust the police may not call them, and many women do not report rape or spousal abuse for fear of being blamed

Kuwait’s Crime Figures: The Public Prosecution’s Annual Report

- The most detailed recent crime figures for Kuwait come from the **Public Prosecution’s annual report**. It counts **cases registered with prosecutors**, not reports to police
- Its list of “prominent crimes” (أبرز الجرائم) includes murder, theft, and drugs
- It also tracks **bribery**, failure to submit **financial disclosure** statements, officials who refuse to carry out **court rulings**, and **medical malpractice**: white-collar crimes the FBI index leaves out

> Before a crime reaches this report, it passes several filters.

Victimization Surveys Ask Ordinary People

- **Victimization survey** — a survey that questions ordinary people, not police officers, to learn whether they have been victims of crime. The U.S. National Crime Victimization Survey began in **1972**
- Its limits: victims must **understand** what happened to them and be **willing to tell** an interviewer. Fraud and blackmail rarely appear
- **In Kuwait:** Gallup's World Poll asks similar questions. In 2023, **4 percent** of adults said they had been assaulted or mugged in the past year, and **1 percent** that money or property had been stolen from their household (Gallup 2024)

Gallup interviews about 1,000 adults in Kuwait by phone, in Arabic, English, Bengali, or Hindi.

> Why is it useful to sociologists to have victimization surveys in addition to reported crime data?

Crime Trends: The Long Decline in U.S. Crime

- U.S. violent crime has **declined significantly**. The 2017 crime rate was comparable to that of **1963**
- Murders fell from **24,700** in 1991 to **15,498** in 2018. Violent and property crime each dropped about **20 percent** in ten years (Table 7-4)
- The pandemic scrambled the pattern: street robberies and home burglaries plummeted as people stayed home, while retail burglaries rose (Sawyer 2020)

Crime Trends in Kuwait, 2020–2025: Cases at the Public Prosecution

Cases registered	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025
All cases	22,803	30,094	39,795	46,566	46,250	49,763
Murder and attempted murder	87	97	71	100	65	69
Felony theft	1,720	1,664	1,591	1,593	1,360	1,313
Drugs and psychotropic substances	1,777	2,363	2,687	2,666	3,149	3,066
Press, media, and IT crimes	1,949	2,205	3,086	3,747	4,059	5,323
Forgery of bank documents	1,078	1,086	1,460	2,532	2,651	3,822

- Total cases **more than doubled**, while felony theft **fell by about a quarter**
- Homicide is rare by international standards: about **0.8** per 100,000 people in Kuwait (2022), against **5.8** in the United States (2023) (UNODC)

> Is crime in Kuwait rising? Which row would a news story choose to say yes? Which row would it choose to say no?

Gallup’s Global Safety Report: How Safe Kuwait Residents Feel at Night

> Gallup asks adults in more than 140 countries: “Do you feel safe walking alone at night in the city or area where you live?” What share of Kuwait’s residents do you think said yes?

- **2023: 99 percent**, the highest of 140 countries. Kuwait also had the highest score on Gallup’s Law and Order Index, **98 out of 100**
- **2024: 91 percent**. Singapore (98), Tajikistan (95), China and Oman (94), and Saudi Arabia (93) ranked above Kuwait (91)
- Worldwide, **73 percent** said yes in 2024

> Did Kuwait become less safe in one year, or is something else moving the number? Each year’s sample is about 1,000 people.

Kuwait’s 2025 Traffic Law and the Fall in Traffic Deaths

- Kuwait’s amended traffic law took effect on **22 April 2025**. Fines rose sharply: using a phone while driving went from **KD 5 to KD 75**
- The Ministry of Interior credits stricter enforcement, more monitoring cameras, and awareness campaigns

January–June	2024	2025	Change
Traffic violations	1,968,733	1,659,448	−16%
Traffic accidents	2,511	1,383	−45%
Traffic deaths	143	94	−34%

> Higher fines, more cameras, and awareness campaigns all arrived together. What data would you need to tell which one saved lives? Could fewer recorded violations mean anything other than better driving?

Deviance in Your Life and Your Field

What looked like individual character, a bad kid, a respectable executive, an obedient volunteer, follows patterns of labels, groups, opportunity, and power. You now have names for them.

Moskos's Patrol Explained with the Chapter's Concepts

Use the chapter's vocabulary to explain what Moskos saw in Baltimore.

- "Police don't deal with a random cross-section of society": **crime statistics** measure **police activity**, not all crime
- A fellow officer who "has their back": **conformity** to peers, alongside **obedience** to commanders
- Police deciding whom to stop and whom to arrest: **labeling theory**, **agents of social control**, and **differential justice**
- Argue it two ways. **Functionalist:** enforcement marks the limits of proper behavior. **Conflict:** who decides which neighborhoods get the most patrols, and which crimes get the least attention?

Sociology in Your Major

- **Medicine:** Goffman's stigma affects who seeks care and who hides a diagnosis. Milgram's teachers obeyed a man in a technician's coat; hospitals run on white coats and orders
- **Engineering:** speed bumps and traffic cameras are social control built into the road
- **Business:** white-collar and corporate crime, embezzlement punished more lightly than petty theft, and Merton's ritualist in every bureaucracy
- **Computer science:** cybercrime, identity theft, music piracy that carries no stigma, and virtual reality replications of Milgram

Before You Leave

- **Deviance** violates a group's standards. It is socially defined, changes over time, and may carry a **stigma** (Goffman)
- **Social control** runs from informal to formal sanctions. Milgram separated **conformity** to peers from **obedience** to authority, and almost two-thirds of his subjects obeyed
- **Law** is governmental social control. **Control theory** (Hirschi): our bonds to others keep most of us conforming
- **Perspectives:** functionalist (Durkheim, Merton), interactionist (Sutherland, Shaw and McKay, Becker, Chambliss), conflict (Quinney)
- **Crime** comes in six types. **Statistics** undercount it, and most people think crime is rising even when it falls
- The **death penalty** debate turns on deterrence, cost, unequal legal defense, and wrongful convictions

Next: Chapter 8, Stratification and Social Mobility.